

you can actually get it for. Or it may simply be way too cheap for the store to make any money on it. A better way to approach this is to know the bottom-line price the store is willing to let the merchandise go for. Sale ads are great resources for this. If you know that a chair went on sale for \$99 last month, then you know that this is a price they are probably comfortable selling it for.

2. Bring evidence

In addition to competitors' ads for the same week (which many stores honor without haggling), keep a record of sale ads for that same store for the past six months or so. If you see an appliance on sale in March, but don't have the money, save the sale ad until you do. Bring that same ad with you when you're ready to make your purchase, and you have just proven that you know your stuff. Most stores won't deny you their own best prices—especially if it moves merchandise.

3. Start high

While many upscale stores may have trained their entry-level sales associates on how to give discounts, don't assume that it will be easy. If you can locate a manager right away, don't be

afraid to approach them directly with your offer. It will take much less time, and by doing so, you will build a relationship with that manager (which will come in handy when you ask for another discount at a later date).

4. Leave the door open

After you have made your sale purchase, clarify the store's (or manager's) policy on similar transactions for future items. Would they be willing to discount another large purchase in a week or so? What kind of items do they see going on sale next month? Did you thank them kindly for their discount? By building a relationship with your favorite stores, you are doing more than haggling. You are networking a future of savings opportunities.

Once you make your first successful "off-sale" purchase, you will become confident in your abilities. Why shop the old way ever again?

—Linsey Knerl